

LIGHTING UNLIMITED × SHOPIFY

A self-serve B2B storefront — without leaving DDI behind

A branded, login-gated ordering portal where your contractors and accounts log in, see their own pricing, and place orders on their own — so counter sales scale without the phone calls and paper tickets.

Shopify Plus · B2B portal · DDI-integrated · 4 Arizona branches

CURRENT STATE

How it works right now

A quick map of today's stack and the three ways customers buy — so we only rebuild what's worth rebuilding.

Systems today

- **ERP:** DDI (distributor ERP) — stays the system of record; you may evaluate NetSuite down the line
- **E-commerce:** none currently (previous site retired); manual listings on Amazon & eBay, low volume
- **Payments:** a separate card processor (buying-group negotiated rates); most sales are on terms / AR
- **Buying group:** Affiliated Distributors — channel & pricing agreements to preserve

Three ways customers buy

- **Counter & pop-up pricing** — walk-in / phone, pre-coded tier pricing. ← **the best fit to move online**
- **Outside sales / spec jobs** — complex quotes, large POs (e.g. \$100k retrofits). Stays in DDI
- **Municipal / contract** — blanket POs & pre-negotiated annual pricing; one city requires an online PO portal

Pricing complexity

Tiers today are bronze / silver / gold, moving toward a cleaner bronze / silver / gold / platinum model — with customer-category modifiers (electrician vs. general contractor vs. property management). Net terms (net 30 / 45 / 60) are common. This tier count is the main thing that decides the plan (below).

USE CASES

What we'd build on Shopify

Straight from our conversation — mapped to Shopify B2B capabilities. Core = we'll validate feasibility in the technical discovery.

Self-serve ordering

CORE

Account customers log in and place their own orders at their agreed pricing — no phone call or counter visit required.

Login-gated catalog

CORE

Products visible only after login on your branded site — protects manufacturer channel rules and buying-group agreements.

Customer-specific pricing & tiers

CORE

Catalogs & price lists per company/tier (bronze→platinum) plus category modifiers, driven by who's logged in.

B2B payment terms

CORE

Net 30 / 45 / 60 and pay-on-account, so online ordering matches how your customers already pay.

Municipal / contract portal

CORE

Upload pre-negotiated blanket pricing — covers the city that requires an online portal to cut POs.

DDI integration

CORE

Orders & fulfillment sync with DDI; outside-sales quotes handled as draft orders; complex jobs stay in DDI.

Payments & Shop Pay

COMPARE

Shopify Payments unlocks Shop Pay; or keep an approved third-party processor (+~0.2% on Plus). We'll compare vs. your buying-group rate.

In-store POS

OPTIONAL

Unify counter sales across the four branches on Shopify POS later — weighed against your current processor's value.

Explicitly out of scope for now: the large, complex spec/quote jobs and \$100k POs — those stay in DDI. Shopify targets the repeatable counter & account ordering that eats the most manual time.

PLANS & PRICING

Shopify Plus

Your model — four pricing tiers with category modifiers, net payment terms, municipal contract pricing and a login-gated catalog — needs the full B2B suite. That points to **one plan: Shopify Plus**. The core plans cap catalogs and price lists and can't handle this pricing structure.

YOUR PLAN

Shopify Plus

\$2,300 /mo base

At ~\$19M B2B revenue you're above the ~\$7.9M threshold, so billing runs on the Variable Platform Fee — **~\$2,850/mo effective** (see below). Full B2B suite, built for your pricing model.

- **Unlimited** companies, customer catalogs & price lists
- **Tiered pricing** — bronze / silver / gold / platinum + category modifiers
- **Net payment terms** (net 30/45/60) & pay-on-account
- Login-gated B2B storefront + wholesale & D2C on one store
- Municipal / contract catalogs with pre-negotiated pricing
- Draft orders, checkout customization, expansion stores
- **1 month free — a \$2,300 credit when you sign by Sept 30**

Payments

Shopify Payments — standard cards	2.25% + 30¢
Shopify Payments — Amex	2.95% + 30¢
Approved third-party processor (keep yours)	+ ~0.2% on Plus

Platform cost at your volume

You pay the **higher of** the \$2,300/mo base or the Variable Platform Fee (VPF). At **~\$19M in revenue** you're above the ~\$7.9M threshold, so VPF applies — and it's charged by channel. Because you're **~92% B2B**, the rate that matters is the lowest one:

B2B — your primary channel	0.18%
Retail (POS)	0.25%
D2C (online)	0.35%
Effective platform cost — B2B 0.18% × ~\$19M	≈ \$34,200/yr (~\$2,850/mo)

The numbers — Year 1 vs. ongoing

Two buckets: a **one-time build** with Solo Media, and your **ongoing Shopify Plus** platform (billed by Shopify). Shopify handles hosting, security and upgrades — no servers on your side.

Shopify Plus platform — VPF 0.18% × ~\$19M B2B ≈ \$34,200/yr (~\$2,850/mo)

One-time — Solo Media build	\$30,000–
SOW SMG-2026-LU-001 · B2B build + DDI integration + WordPress migration ·	\$35,000
milestones 40% / 35% / 25% = \$14,000 / \$12,250 / \$8,750	

Year 1 — platform + build	≈ \$64,200–\$69,200
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Ongoing (Yr 2+) — platform only; Shopify handles hosting, security & upgrades	≈ \$34,200/yr (~\$2,850/mo)
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Monthly view — Year 1 blended (build included)	~\$5,350–\$5,770/mo → ~\$2,850/mo after
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Two things that lower this: the **1 month free on Plus** credits back ~\$2,300 on a Sept 30 signature, and apps (e.g. Matrixify for the DDI/CSV sync) run only ~\$50–200/mo — both kept *out* of the Year-1 figure above so it stays conservative.

Solo Media SOW #SMG-2026-LU-001 is a draft: the current \$35,000 figure assumes a scheduled CSV/Matrixify DDI sync (range \$30K–\$35K); if DDI exposes API endpoints for a real-time integration, Solo Media confirms any adjustment before an executed SOW. Includes 30 days of post-launch defect fixes; ongoing dev at \$150/hr or a monthly retainer. Shopify POS is a separate future phase. The 1-month-free Plus incentive (a \$2,300 credit) applies on a Sept 30 signature. Platform figure based on ~\$19M B2B at the 0.18% VPF rate; card rates & incentives confirmed on the order form.

Cash-flow & signing: the Plus agreement is **post-dated to Sept 30**, so you can sign as soon as you're ready and still lock the incentive. With the **1 month free**, your **first platform payment isn't due until ~Nov 30** — you build through the free month before any platform bill arrives.

ROI & PAYBACK

What you get back — and how fast

A self-serve B2B portal pays for itself three ways: **incremental revenue** from accounts that reorder more when they can buy on their own, **recovered labor** as manual phone/counter/paper orders move online, and **revenue you'd otherwise lose** (the city contract that requires an online PO portal). The calculator below is fully editable — start with our conservative planning defaults, then flex them for the owner.

Your assumptions

1%
Conservative

3%
Moderate

5%
Aggressive

Annual B2B
revenue

\$

19000000

Revenue uplift from
self-serve

3

incremental % of B2B
revenue

%

Your gross margin

25

distributor avg ~22–
28%

%

Manual orders
moved online / wk

75

phone + counter +
paper tickets

Minutes saved per
order

8

Loaded labor cost /
hr

\$

28

Year-1 investment

\$

66700

Solo Media build + Year-
1 Plus platform

ADDED REVENUE / YEAR

\$570,000

GROSS PROFIT ON THAT REVENUE

\$142,500

RECOVERED LABOR / YEAR

\$14,560

TOTAL ANNUAL BENEFIT (PROFIT + LABOR)

\$157,060

PAYBACK ON YOUR INVESTMENT

5.1 MO

Payback is measured against what actually recoups cash — **gross profit** on the incremental revenue plus **recovered labor** — not top-line revenue. Year-1 net, after the build and a first-year adoption ramp: **+\$27,536**.

Payback by scenario

Conservative · +1%

13 MO

+\$190,000
REVENUE/YR

Moderate · +3%

5.1 MO

+\$570,000
REVENUE/YR

Aggressive · +5%

3.2 MO

+\$950,000
REVENUE/YR

TCO & break-even — by year

Operating years from launch, at the moderate (+3%) case. Year 1 carries the one-time build and a first-year adoption ramp (benefit shown at ~60% as accounts come online); Year 2+ is platform only (~\$34,200/yr). Updates live with the calculator above.

By year	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Cost (TCO)	\$66,700	\$34,200	\$34,200
Benefit (profit + labor)	\$94,236	\$157,060	\$157,060
Net for the year	+\$27,536	+\$122,860	+\$122,860
Cumulative net	+\$27,536 BREAK-EVEN	+\$150,396	+\$273,256

At your steady run-rate the build is recovered in about 5.1 mo; factoring the one-time build and a first-year adoption ramp, **cumulative net turns positive in Year 1**.

The cost of standing still

Waiting isn't free — the status quo carries its own bill, straight from what you told us about how Lighting Unlimited runs today:

Benefit not captured — every month you wait

≈ \$13,088/mo

forgone gross profit on uplift + labor still spent keying orders by hand

- **The city PO-portal contract is exposed.** You've already won municipal business that **requires an online ordering portal** — until it exists, that revenue isn't serviceable and stays at risk.
- **Manual order entry keeps eating hours.** Nearly every order today is a walk-in, phone call, or hand-written ticket on your pricing matrix — a cost that **grows with volume** and doesn't scale.
- **Growth means another hire, not another automation.** Without self-serve, more counter/account volume means adding headcount instead of letting customers order themselves.
- **Customers asking to self-serve can go elsewhere.** Accounts that want to log in and re-order may take repeat business to distributors who already offer it.
- **The Sept 30 incentive expires.** The **1 month free on Plus (\$2,300 credit)** is tied to a Sept 30 signature — wait past it and Year 1 simply costs more.

Revenue you keep, not just grow: you've already won a **city contract that requires an online PO portal** — without the portal that business isn't serviceable. That revenue is **defended by this build on day one**, before any uplift, and it isn't counted in the numbers above.

Why the revenue uplift is real (not wishful)

- **Reorder convenience.** Accounts that can log in and re-order at their own pricing buy more often — no waiting on a callback or a counter visit.
- **Bigger baskets.** A browsable, always-on catalog surfaces items a phone order skips; B2B buyers self-serving typically add lines they'd otherwise forget.
- **Capacity to grow without headcount.** Every order that self-serves frees your counter/phone team to chase new accounts and quotes instead of keying tickets.
- **Always open.** Customers order after hours and on weekends — demand you can't capture on the phone today.

Defaults are deliberately conservative planning figures, not a forecast — we modeled a small slice of your \$19M and a distributor-typical margin. Swap in your real margin and order-volume numbers and the payback updates live. Labor savings assume orders that fully self-serve; partial time savings still count.

NEXT STEPS

The path to launch — a Sept 30 start, live before year-end

Scope is locked in Solo Media's SOW, so this is a clean **Sept 30 start** and an **8–12 week parallel build** — live comfortably before the holidays (and ahead of Jan 1). The **DDI integration** and the **B2B order-review workflow** are the pacing items: a CSV sync compresses toward 8 weeks; a real-time DDI API pushes toward 12.

The next three steps

1. **Green light.** Owner + CFO give the OK to move forward — targeting this week.
2. **We create your account & send the URL.** Nicole spins up your Shopify Plus store and sends you the link so you can log in and explore it firsthand.
3. **Contract for your review.** Nicole sends the Plus agreement + Solo Media SOW over for you to review — sign by **Sept 30** to lock the 1 month free (\$2,300).

● Today · Sept 21 — partner + SE working session

Walk the build. Solo Media reviews the plan and the DDI integration approach; the **Statement of Work (\$35,000 fixed, CSV-sync assumption)** is on the table. *Solo Media · Shopify SE · you.*

● Sept 22–24 · owner & CFO review

Take it up the chain. Harrison walks the plan + SOW to the owner and new CFO; feedback back to us **Tuesday or Wednesday**. *You.*

● On a green light · account + URL + contract

We move fast. Nicole spins up your Shopify Plus account and sends you the store URL to explore, plus the Plus agreement + Solo Media SOW for your review. *Shopify · Solo Media.*

● Sept 30 · start date

Sign & kick off. Execute the Plus agreement + SOW (40% / \$14,000 kickoff). The Plus agreement is **post-dated to Sept 30**, so you can sign anytime before then to lock your **1 month free (\$2,300)** — and with the free month, your **first platform payment isn't due until ~Nov 30**. *You (sign) · all.*

🟡 Weeks 1–2 · discovery & setup

Requirements workshop, DDI data mapping (products, pricing, inventory, images, customers), the **API-vs-CSV integration decision**, and the Plus store + dev store stood up.
Solo Media · Harrison.

🟡 Weeks 2–6 · the build

Storefront + **WordPress migration**, **B2B Companies & Catalogs** (tiered + SKU pricing), the **order-review workflow** (review gate + payment holds via Flow), and net-terms invoicing.
Solo Media.

🟡 Mid-build · DDI integration (the long pole)

Sync products, pricing, inventory & images + order write-back to DDI, with a **downtime queue** and customer-facing notification bar; on-demand customer-onboarding templates.
Solo Media · Harrison.

🟡 Weeks ~7–10 · QA & training

End-to-end QA of the B2B + retail flows, then SOPs and live training so your team runs daily ops (CSV uploads, order review). *You · Solo Media.*

🟢 ~Late Nov – late Dec · launch & cutover

Go live on Shopify Plus. Full 301-redirect map, zero-downtime domain switch, post-launch stabilization. The CSV path lands ~late Nov; the API path ~late Dec — **before Jan 1** either way. *All.*

What we need from you

- Owner + CFO feedback by Tue/Wed (Sept 22–24)
- Green light to create your Shopify Plus account
- Review the Plus agreement + Solo Media SOW (we'll send them over) — sign by Sept 30 to lock the start date and your 1 month free (\$2,300)
- Facilitate DDI access at kickoff — it's the pacing item that protects the date

Honest read: starting Sept 30, an 8–12 week build lands you live before year-end — even the real-time DDI API path (~12 weeks) finishes ahead of Jan 1. The two make-or-break items are **DDI access** (so the integration isn't blocked) and the **Sept 30 signature**. If DDI turns out heavier than scoped, we protect the date by launching the core portal first and adding the municipal portal / POS right after.

What your owner & CFO will likely ask — and the answer

- **"It works today — why spend?"** Your customers are asking to self-serve, you just won a city contract that requires an online portal, and this scales counter/phone volume without adding headcount.
- **"Is the DDI integration risky?"** Solo Media is a Shopify Platinum partner (500+ migrations, ERP integrations included). Worst case, we use the same CSV / scheduled-sync model you already run with SmartSheets — and DDI stays your source of truth.
- **"Do we have to rip out our POS / payment processing?"** No. Online-first; your DDI POS keeps running in parallel. In-store/POS is a later phase.
- **"Who maintains it — we have no IT?"** Shopify runs the platform (uptime, security, upgrades, servers). You edit content yourselves and Solo Media hands over documentation (optional retainer for ongoing custom work). Plus you get Shopify Plus support, a Customer Success Manager, and Nicole + Angel supporting you long-term.
- **"We just moved to a new payment processor a year ago — not doing that again."** You don't have to. This is a **new online channel**; your counter/in-store setup and the processor you just switched to keep running untouched. For the online store you can turn on Shopify Payments *or* keep your current processor as an approved third-party gateway on Plus (+~0.2%). Nothing here undoes last year's switch.
- **"We're spending elsewhere right now — hiring and a buyout."** This is sized to **protect** that spend, not compete with it. The build is a fixed one-time \$30–35K on milestones (not upfront), and self-serve grows counter/account volume **without adding headcount** — so it stretches the hiring budget. With the Sept 30 incentive and the post-dated agreement, your **first platform payment isn't due until ~Nov 30**, easing cash flow while the buyout closes.
- **"What if we move off DDI to a new ERP around 2030?"** Shopify sits **on top of** your ERP through a defined sync — it isn't welded to DDI. If you move to NetSuite (already on your radar) or another ERP later, you **re-point the same integration** to the new system; the storefront, customer accounts, tier pricing and order history all stay put. You swap what feeds the store, not the store itself — and connectors exist for NetSuite and the other major ERPs.

- **"Timeline?"** Jan 1 is feasible — an OK from the owners this week, a Sept 30 signature/kickoff, and DDI as the critical path, so the sooner we start the safer the date.

How we help you prep: send over any concerns — or the specific hesitations you expect from your owner/CFO — and we'll help you prep the answers ahead of time. We're also glad to **join the owner conversation**, or be on **standby** to jump in and answer questions live.

Prepared by Nicole DeGennaro · Shopify — for Lighting Unlimited. Built from our intro call. B2B feasibility confirmed in technical discovery; pricing & scope finalized with an implementation partner.